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Telecom Fraud Detection: How To Protect Your Business From Rising Threats

This article was updated on February 6, 2026

Telecom fraud can cost businesses a huge amount of money, and it's on the rise. In fact, there was a 141% increase in the volume of digital account takeover from H1 2021 to H1 2025, according TransUnion. Global revenue losses for telecommunications companies due to fraud are estimated to be around $50 billion annually. Businesses and consumers will always be at risk of fraud in one form or another. However, you can reduce this risk through preparation. In this guide, we'll cover everything you need to know about telecom fraud.



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See bio

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Telecom fraud detection is the process of identifying, flagging, and stopping suspicious activity across your communication systems. It protects your business from financial loss, brand damage, and customer churn, often before the fraud ever reaches your customers.

Here's what effective telecom fraud detection includes ...

- **Real-time monitoring** of calls, messages, account logins, and network usage
- **Risk scoring** to assess the likelihood that a number or user is fraudulent
- **Behavioral analytics** that leverage machine learning to detect unusual patterns
- **Omnichannel protection** that covers voice, messages, apps, and APIs
- **Instant alerts and automation**, such as blocking high-risk traffic or pausing accounts

Done right, fraud detection doesn't just defend your systems, it can become a competitive advantage, helping you lower costs, maintain trust, and keep communications flowing securely.

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Telecom fraud detection uses artificial intelligence and machine learning to monitor communications systems in real time and flag suspicious activity, including SIM swapping, subscription abuse, and international revenue share fraud. Detection tools help telecom providers reduce losses, while consumers can take proactive steps to protect their accounts and data.

For telecom companies

- **Apply AI and ML:** Analyze large volumes of call, message, and network data to spot abnormal activity or user behavior in real time.
- **Track network behavior:** Watch for red flags like spoofed caller IDs, unexpected call routing, or unauthorized PBX access.
- **Enable dynamic blocking:** Use fraud scoring and routing controls to automatically stop or reroute high-risk traffic before it causes disruption.
- **Strengthen identity verification:** Enforce MFA (multi-factor authentication) and other customer authentication tools to reduce the risk of takeovers.
- **Screen partners and vendors:** Only work with verified providers to avoid exposure to third-party fraud.

For end users

- **Review your monthly statements:** Unexpected charges or unfamiliar calls may be signs of an ongoing fraud attempt.
- **Guard your personal information:** Never give out sensitive data in response to unsolicited messages or calls.
- **Screen unknown callers:** Let unknown numbers go to voicemail; scammers rarely leave a message.
- **Use national do-not-call lists:** Redu
robocalls, many of which are scam-rel

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Telecom fraud refers to any deliberate misuse of phone systems or communications networks to steal money, bypass charges, or disrupt services. This often includes exploiting vulnerabilities in call routing, SMS messaging, or authentication systems to generate fraudulent charges or gain unauthorized access.

Telecom fraud impacts both businesses and consumers, from inflated invoices and international toll charges to account hijacking and stolen customer data. Left undetected, it can cause serious financial and reputational harm.

Common methods used by telecom fraudsters

Most telecom fraud starts with unauthorized access. Fraudsters may use stolen credentials, phishing schemes, or malware to break into communication platforms. Once inside, they often:

- Reroute calls through high-cost destinations
- Register fake premium numbers to collect fees
- Hijack SIM cards or PBX systems
- Spoof phone numbers to impersonate legitimate contacts

These attacks are designed to avoid detection and escalate quickly, which is why strong, real-time telecom fraud detection systems are so essential.

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common types

Telecom technology is constantly evolving to keep up with the world and the way businesses operate. Unfortunately, hackers and malicious groups are also constantly upgrading their attack methods.

Let's examine 12 common types of **telecommunications fraud**.

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Fraud Type	Voice & SMS Fraud	Data Privacy Breach	Revenue Loss	Reputational Damage	Billing Shock
PBX Hacking	Yes	Possibly	Yes	Possibly	Yes
SMS Phishing	Yes	Yes	Possibly	Yes	No
Wangiri Fraud	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
IRSF Scams	Yes	No	Yes	Possibly	Yes
SIM Swapping	Yes	Yes	Yes	Possibly	Yes
SIM Box Fraud	Yes	No	Yes	Possibly	Yes
Traffic Pumping	Yes	No	Yes	Possibly	Yes
Deposit Fraud	Possibly	Possibly	Yes	No	No
Subscription Fraud	Yes	Yes	Yes	Possibly	Possibly
Account Takeover	Yes	Yes			
Call Forwarding	Yes	Possibly			

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Malware
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1. PBX hacking

A private branch exchange (PBX) is useful for consolidating multiple phone lines for internal and external calls. It saves you money and streamlines call routing. At the same time, a PBX presents scammers with an opportunity to infiltrate your network. However, hacking on-premises solutions requires someone to physically access your telecoms equipment, making it harder, but not impossible.

Compared to a traditional private branch exchange (PBX), IP-based and virtual PBX solutions are even easier targets for hackers. They can brute force or acquire credentials through other means to gain access to the system. Once inside, they can use the service to dial premium numbers or divert calls to overpriced local carriers.

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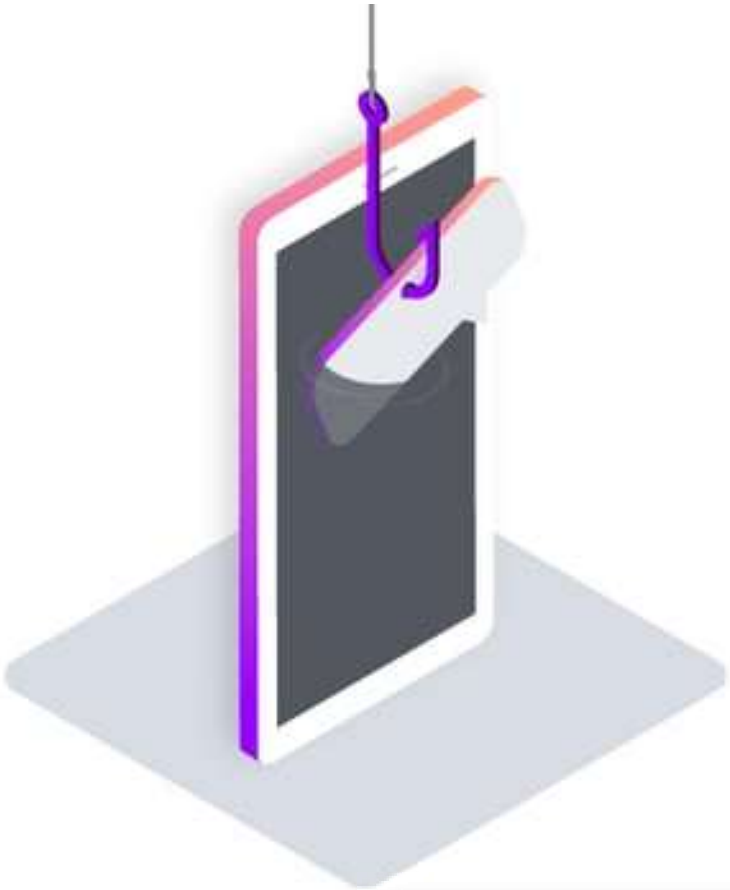
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SMS phishing, also known as smishing, involves sending deceptive text messages to trick recipients into giving out personal information. Scammers can use these details for a variety of purposes, including withdrawing money, changing account details to their own, or accessing telecom networks.

Sophisticated smishers use modern software to help them avoid fraud detection in telecom businesses. For example, they can avoid flagging a detection system by only targeting mobile phone numbers when sending scam texts.

SMS phishing is one of many social engineering tactics and is often used alongside similar attacks on other channels, such as email and social media platforms. Tools like Vonage Identity Insights API detect fraud, block unverified numbers, and help prevent phishing activities.



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someone receiving a call that hangs up before they can answer (usually after one ring). The recipient quickly calls back the number to find out who was calling. Unbeknownst to the caller, they are dialing a premium rate number.

If someone from your organization returns a missed call without caution, you'll be stuck with the inflated connection fees. Monitoring call origins helps you avoid falling victim to Wangiri fraud.

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4. IRSF scams

IRSF stands for International Revenue Share Fraud. With IRSF, fraudsters exploit billing agreements between carriers to artificially inflate service bills. Malicious actors use various techniques to intercept and redirect outbound calls to premium numbers or local carriers with extortionate rates. The partner numbers are paid for providing unnecessary service while scammers take a slice of the inflated pie.

Here's a typical example of an IRSF scam...

1. A scammer or proxy signs up for a premium phone number.

2. They intercept a call and direct the consumer or business phone system to dial and connect with the leased premium number.

3. The dialer is hit with the premium rate

IRSF often results in billing shock when cl
expected. Keeping an eye on your telecon

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Despite the name, SIM swapping, also called SIM jacking, isn't changing the physical card in a mobile device. Instead, fraudsters use a customer's personal identifying information to access a telecom account.

With this information, scammers convince customer service to switch the phone number to a SIM card they control. These cybercriminals can now access text messages, emails, bank accounts, and other sensitive information. SIM jacking provides scammers with one-time passwords (OTP) and multifactor verification (MFA) codes.

How can you prevent SIM swapping for your team? Train your employees never to give out personal or password details. You can also set up internal 2FA with Vonage Verify API or a similar communications solution to ensure swaps are legitimate.



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used to make international calls appear as local calls. When the call finishes, the termination rate becomes the final cost rate. Using a SIM box, fraudsters reroute long-distance calls to appear as local calls.

These calls have cheaper rates, stealing revenue from carriers and telco companies.

SIM box scammers aren't the Robin Hood of telecommunications, however. The customer still pays the full price, while the fraudster pockets the savings from illegally rerouting the call. Plus, due to the technology involved in SIM box fraud, the call quality will be low, leaving your customers frustrated with poor service and likely to take their business elsewhere.

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7. Traffic pumping

With traffic pumping, a local carrier inflates the number of calls that connect from a primary operator. It is also known as access stimulation. By manipulating call numbers, the carrier is compensated according to regulatory agreements such as those enforced by the Federal Communications Commission (FCC).

Access stimulation artificially inflates your operational costs. Overloading networks can also cause network congestion and drops in call quality. Individual customers may see overcharges from calls of undetermined origin.

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Deposit fraud starts with tactics like social engineering and phishing scams. Cybercriminals use stolen information to transfer money to a new bank account or acquire personal information to trick the victim into transferring the money into an unknown bank account themselves. Before the victim realizes what they've done, the money has already been withdrawn.

However, cybercriminals might also use this money to purchase things like prepaid SIMs, mobile devices, and carrier contracts. This results in customer chargebacks for false purchases, which can result in lost revenue for providers and extra headaches for your payment processing department.



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card information to sign up for carrier contracts. They can bypass Know Your Customer (KYC) verification by using someone else's personal identifying information.

One main target of this type of fraud is mobile phone contracts that include a device. Of course, there is no intent to pay for the phone. Instead, fraudsters unlock the device and flip it.

There are two common types of subscription fraud...

- Application fraud is the use of fraudulent or stolen identification to sign up for telecom services. Accounts that are flagged for fraud after the fact result in lost revenue for the business, while victims of impersonation will likely have issues with their credit ratings and/or financial losses to recoup from the bank.

- Credit mule scams involve more informed individuals, where scammers enlist people to successfully pass KYC verification. Credit mules are compensated for their efforts, though they may not knowingly be deceiving the mobile providers.

10. Account takeover

Account takeover (ATO) fraud is a form of identity theft where a hacker gains access to a user account. Unfortunately, online convenience provides cybercriminals with plenty of opportunities to gain entry into user accounts.

Like much of telecom fraud, ATO is driven by social engineering efforts. Fraudsters may pose as representatives from your company to gain user account credentials. They can phish with sophisticated means, such as intercepting web traffic with fake sites made to look legitimate.

Once inside the account, the hacker has access to all account information, including credit card or bank account details.

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11. Call forwarding fraud

Call forwarding is a useful feature of personal and business phone services. Unfortunately, like every bit of evolving telecom technology, its purpose has been flipped on its head by scammers. Malicious actors fool users into enabling call forwarding to phone numbers they control. In this way, the user has directed calls or texts to the fraudster, where they can steal sensitive information.

Call forwarding fraud is often a small part of a bigger picture. One common use is having verification calls forwarded to a fraudster who can then access bank accounts or make large online transactions.

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Mobile malware fraud occurs when users unknowingly download malicious software. Once installed, the software operates in the background. Malware sends personal details and login credentials for other apps such as banking software to hackers. It may also cause performance issues on the affected device.

Statista reports that the first quarter of 2024 saw users download about 34 billion apps in total from Google Play and the Apple App Store. While many of the apps will be legitimate, some will also act as a cover for malware. For example, BioCatch reported that malware fraud increased by 113% in 2024 in Latin America.



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Effective fraud detection combines real-time analysis, machine learning, and automation to identify threats as they emerge, before they can do harm.

Key mechanisms include:

- Traffic pattern analysis: Scans for irregular call volumes, routing anomalies, or activity outside of normal hours.
- Device and number intelligence: Flags suspicious SIM or phone number behavior using fraud databases.
- Geo and velocity checks: Detects suspicious activity across multiple locations or rapid-fire verifications.
- Behavioral biometrics: Analyzes how users interact (e.g., typing patterns) to spot impersonators.
- Automated alerts and actions: Suspends risky accounts or routes traffic for re-verification without human intervention.

Over time, machine learning adapts to new patterns, improving accuracy while reducing false positives.

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Telecom fraud detection isn't just about avoiding losses, it's a strategic investment in your business's growth, resilience, and reputation. When implemented effectively, fraud detection strengthens operations and deepens customer trust.

Here's how it drives long-term business value:

Operational continuity

Fraud can disrupt communication flows and internal systems. Early detection ensures your business stays connected, even under threat, with minimal downtime or service interruptions.

Customer confidence & loyalty

Customers expect secure, seamless communication. When you proactively detect and stop fraud, you protect them from inflated bills, phishing, and account compromise, earning their trust and long-term loyalty.

Future-proof security posture

Modern fraud detection tools adapt to evolving threats using behavioral analytics and AI. This keeps your defenses ahead of attackers, reducing future risk and exposure.

Predictable costs and fewer surprises

By catching threats early, you reduce the chance of sudden expenses like chargebacks, overage fees, or network abuse, helping keep your budget stable and forecasts reliable.

With fraud detection in place, you're not just reacting to threats, you're building a stronger, more resilient business that ca

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Detecting telecom fraud at scale requires a combination of proactive monitoring, real-time data analysis, and automation. Leading telecom providers and carriers use a layered detection strategy that enables them to spot suspicious activity early and minimize risk before it escalates.

Here are some of the most effective fraud detection methods used across the telecom industry:

1. Traffic pattern monitoring

Network operations teams watch for unusual surges in call volume, especially toward international or premium-rate destinations, which often signal fraud in progress.

2. Call Detail Record (CDR) Analysis

By analyzing metadata like call duration, time of day, and destination numbers, providers can identify usage anomalies, such as repeated short calls to expensive numbers or traffic outside business hours.

3. SIM and number intelligence

Suspicious SIM behavior (e.g., SIM swaps or multiple registrations) and unverified numbers are cross-checked against known fraud databases or historical risk scores to block bad actors before they connect.

4. Geo and velocity rules

Fraud systems flag activity when logins, verifications, or calls occur from drastically different geolocations within short time frames, a common sign of account compromise.

5. Behavioral biometrics

More advanced platforms use biometrics
behavior, to distinguish between legitima
mimic them.

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attack patterns, even those that don't match any known threat signature, reducing reliance on rigid rules alone.

7. Automated escalation and blocking

Once suspicious behavior is detected, systems automatically throttle traffic, suspend accounts, or trigger verification flows, reducing time to containment.

This combination of real-time monitoring, intelligence, and automation allows modern telecom operations to stay ahead of fraud trends and respond in seconds, not hours.

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Choosing the right fraud detection platform can help your business protect revenue, comply with regulations, and maintain customer trust. But not all systems offer the same level of coverage, automation, or insight.

Here are the key features to look for when evaluating telecom fraud detection tools:

1. Real-time traffic monitoring

Ensure the platform can analyze voice, SMS, and data streams as they occur, not just in batch, and raise alerts for spikes or suspicious routes.

2. API-based number intelligence

APIs like Vonage Identity Insights help assess phone number risk at the point of interaction. This allows you to detect fraudulent numbers before calls or messages are placed.

3. AI + rule-based detection

Look for platforms that combine traditional rule sets (e.g., call frequency limits) with adaptive machine learning to detect evolving or unknown threat patterns.

4. Automated response capabilities

Best-in-class solutions offer automation to block traffic, suspend users, or trigger multi-factor authentication, minimizing manual effort and damage.

5. Omnichannel fraud coverage

Make sure your detection system spans voice, SMS, chat apps, and APIs, not just one channel, to secure all your customer touchpoints.

6. Flexible scalability & inte

The platform should work with your curre
needs, whether you manage five users or

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audit logs, user access controls, and data protection settings.

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Telecommunications fraud detection and prevention refers to the technologies and strategies used to identify, mitigate, and stop malicious activity across communication systems.

- Fraud detection focuses on monitoring patterns in calls, messages, and user behavior to flag potential threats in real time.

- Fraud prevention involves proactive controls that stop fraud before it affects your network or customers, like traffic filtering, authentication, and access restrictions.

Together, they form the foundation of an effective telecom security framework, ensuring continuity, protecting customers, and reducing financial loss.

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Detection and prevention require coordinated efforts between your team and your customers. Modern cybersecurity solutions can monitor traffic, block threats, and send fraud alerts. While much of this is automated, users must also understand what telecom fraud is and be trained to identify and prevent it.

Let's examine some of the common ways users can help in the fight against fraud.

Monitor and understand bills

The first sign of compromised telecommunications often manifests in the customer's monthly bill. Encourage customers to regularly examine their charges and flag anything unusual.

Checking bills regularly also ensures customers are up to date with their account balance. They won't fall victim to impersonators posing as company reps seeking additional payment.

Be alert when dealing with unknown numbers

While it can't always be helped, customers or employees should avoid answering unfamiliar phone calls. The same goes for unsolicited text messages from unrecognized phone numbers. Users can let unfamiliar calls go to voicemail as a quick filter. Scammers will be unlikely to leave a message and move on to the next potential victim, while legitimate callers will leave details for a callback.

As a general rule, organizations will never ask for personal identification and bank details over

the phone. Make sure customers are aware you will never text or call out of the blue to ask for this information. You can also encourage them to call the details listed on your website directly if they're unsure about a call they receive from you, it's better to be over-cautious than g

Protect personal informatic

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and not provide any more.

They should also protect their online account information by following password management best practices, such as:

- Creating strong, unique passwords using a mix of uppercase letters, lowercase letters, numbers, and special characters
- Avoiding common passwords, such as birthdays, pet names, sports teams, and company names
- Using passwords once, rather than using the same password for multiple accounts
- Turning on multi-factor authentication
- Using password managers to generate and store login credentials

Use the do not call registry

It can be difficult to identify which telemarketers are legit or truly malicious. Your customers can save sweat and tears by signing up for the Do Not Call Registry. Once registered, there's a high likelihood that calls from unknown phone numbers are scammers. In other words, once registered, your customers can safely ignore calls and texts from people they don't know or when caller ID shows "unknown number."

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Cybercriminals are constantly changing their techniques to scam you and your customers out of money. As technology progresses, it will always be possible for digital pirates to plunder those resources. The best way to combat the risks is to stay up-to-date with the newest scammer tactics.

Here are some of the top telecom fraud trends to look for.

1. Subscription fraud: As more organizations go digital, subscription fraud will likely increase. In a recent TransUnion 2025 report, 53% of telecom executives surveyed expressed high concern about new account fraud.

2. Social engineering: As users continue to flock to social media platforms, hackers will continue to pose as legitimate businesses while attempting to gain sensitive information. According to TechRepublic, Social engineering attacks made up 36% of intrusions from May 2024 to May 2025, surpassing malware and exploits as the top breach method.

3. AI-driven fraud: Unfortunately, advances in machine learning and artificial intelligence will improve scammer tactics. GenAI can create scripts to sound professional and impersonate customer service reps. Deepfake AI can help scammers pass sophisticated KYC verifications such as facial recognition. And, with the field developing so quickly, there are likely more AI risks to come.

4. Virtual SIM Cards: Also known as eSIMs, many mobile users are now turning to virtual cards to access regional phone networks. Statista reports there were more than 600 million eSIM smartphone connections in 2024. Like with mobile apps, virtual SIMs provide hackers with an opportunity to gain access and control of customers' phones.

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Telecom fraud is a growing problem because the more connected the world is, the more potential access cybercriminals have to sensitive information

People aren't just moving online to shop or communicate. We're also shifting our work online, with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reporting that nearly one in five workers is working remotely.

Black-hat individuals are co-opting new tech to find new vulnerabilities to exploit. While going virtual has many benefits, such as greater flexibility and increased productivity, it also requires greater security measures to protect personal information.

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Telecom fraud doesn't just steal money, it damages your brand, weakens your organization, and exposes you to lasting reputational and legal consequences. The cost of inaction compounds over time.

Here's what can happen without proper fraud management:

Reputation damage and churn

Customers who fall victim to telecom fraud, even indirectly, are likely to lose trust and switch providers. Word-of-mouth and online reviews can amplify damage, hurting acquisition and retention.

Legal and regulatory fallout

Failure to detect fraud in a timely manner could lead to lawsuits, regulatory penalties, or class action claims, especially in industries with strict compliance standards. Legal fees and settlements only add to the financial toll.

Employer brand and team morale

Talented professionals want to work for secure, forward-thinking companies. Ongoing fraud incidents and public failures can hurt your employer reputation, making it harder to recruit or retain top talent.

Wasted potential and lost opportunities

Every dollar spent on remediating fraud is a dollar not spent on innovation, marketing, or growth. Poor fraud controls limit your ability to scale or enter new markets confidently.

Ignoring telecom fraud won't make it go away, it simply shifts the cost from prevention to clean-up. And the longer it goes unaddressed, the higher the price.

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A telecom fraud protection solution streamlines the detection and prevention of fraudulent activity. Some tools might specialize in one or two key areas while others provide a comprehensive fraud management system in telecom situations.

Here are some ways a telecommunications fraud protection tool can help your business.

1. **Detects and prevents fraud in real time.** The best fraud prevention tools monitor network traffic, call logs, and user behavior in real time, allowing you to immediately identify and respond to fraudulent activities. Instant notifications mean your manager will be alerted to anomalies as soon as possible and be able to take action to prevent losses to the customer and the business.

2. **Save money.** By preventing activities such as subscription fraud and premium-rate service fraud, you can reduce revenue losses from unpaid bills and chargebacks. With an optimized fraud detection program, you should be able to budget better and increase spending in other areas, such as marketing or innovation.

3. **Improve customer trust.** Unsurprisingly, preventing data breaches and identity theft builds consumer trust. By stopping fraudulent charges before they appear on customer bills, you reduce billing shock and customer frustration. Better protection and accurate billing mean more positive customer experiences and an increased chance they'll stay with you as well as recommend you to people they know.

4. **Enhance compliance.** Having strong fraud prevention strategies in place can streamline compliance with data protection laws, such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA), as well as other requirements. This helps avoid legal penalties, sanctions, and reputational damage.

5. **Gain insights.** Algorithms for fraud detection in telecoms can analyze patterns and trends over time. Predict
for future fraud activity. By gaining ins
better distinguish between legitimate
longer you have the tools in place, the

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Telecom fraud continues to evolve, and so should your protection strategy. With attacks growing more sophisticated, the cost of inaction is no longer limited to financial loss. From customer churn to legal liability, the fallout from a single breach can impact every part of your business. That's why proactive, intelligent, and scalable fraud detection is no longer a luxury, it's a necessity.

Vonage Protection Suite empowers you to own your seurity. From real-time fraud detection to seamless identity verification, our platform protects every communication channel, voice, SMS, app messaging, and APIs, so you can operate confidently, without compromise.

At the core is Fraud Defender, which provides continuous monitoring and automated alerts when anomalies are detected, allowing your team to act before damage is done. This is enhanced by Vonage Identity Insights API, which evaluates phone number risk and validity in real time, including critical checks like SIM swap detection, which helps prevent account takeovers by flagging suspicious changes in device control. Paired with Verify API, you can easily layer in two-factor authentication and even implement Silent Authentication, enabling a frictionless login experience that verifies users without additional input, reducing abandonment while preserving security.

But owning your security goes beyond blocking fraud. It means being ready to respond, report, and recover, with tools that support compliance, transparency, and operational agility. Vonage makes that possible with:

- SOC 2 Type II compliance and full audit support
- Vonage Management APIs for streamlined billing, logging, and system oversight
- Reports API to distribute real-time insights across your organization

Live training and onboarding to help your teams get ahead, and stay there

Why Vonage?

- Real-time fraud detection with automa
- Identity and access protection via 2FA

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- Expert training and guidance to help your team stay ahead

Your business communications should be a source of growth, not a liability. With Vonage, you can reduce risk, retain revenue, protect customer trust, and stay ahead of evolving fraud tactics, all within a unified platform that scales with you.

Start building a smarter fraud strategy today and Own Your Security with Vonage.

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SIGN UP NOW

Was this helpful? Let's continue your API journey

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fraud detection

What is telecom fraud detection? ›

How does telecom fraud affect businesses? ›

What are the most common types of telecom fraud? ›

What tools help with telecom fraud detection? ›

How can businesses prevent telecom fraud? ›

Can users help detect or prevent telecom fraud? ›

Is telecom fraud detection automated? ›

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